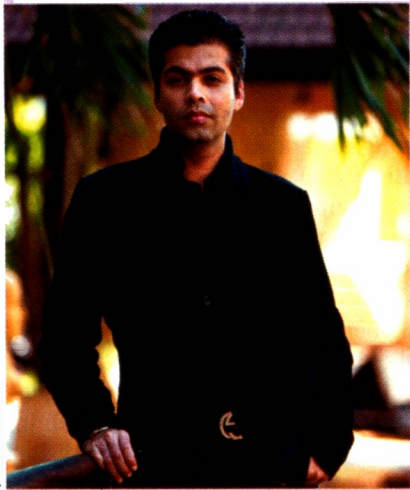


INDEPENDENT PRODUCERS

Indie Rocks

With pedigree and private money, they're on all studio wanna-have lists



SHREYA PATIL, SHINDE

MEN WHO MATTER: Johar; (below) Shah and Bazmee (right)

in on narrations to stars to monitoring the photo shoots) controlling the last paisa of the revenue stream, down to the fragmented territories of Bihar and Orissa, are few and far in between in Bollywood.

But they have something corporates don't have. Pedigree. In varying measure. From YashRaj Films, which has been spending at least Rs 200 crore on four films a year since 2006, to Karan Johar's Dharma Productions which will see three films a year rolling out from 2009, these are Bollywood royalty, who have sniffed at public money, choosing to dig into their own "outflow" from previous movies, snapping up stars with one-line narrations. Then there are newcomers to this privileged lot, like Vipul Shah, who till 10 years ago was an actor on Gujarati stage, and thought he would be lucky if he could make Rs 30,000 a month. Now, having proved himself a successful director with three hits in a row, he has turned producer with *Singh is Kinng* and will direct the once-abandoned Rs 65-crore Rajkumar Santoshi project, *London Dreams*.

What sets these men apart is the relationships they have built with stars over the years. Johar is friends with the Bachchans and Shah Rukh, Shah is close to Akshay, while Sajid Nadiadwala considers himself to be among Salman's friends. Other independents such as Rakesh Roshan's FilmKraft are luckier—they just have to tap their own family. Between them these biggies, which includes Shah Rukh's Red Chillies, are likely to infuse about Rs 1,000 crore into the industry over the next 15 months, significantly altering their own—and the industry's—scale.

We're the last of the Mohicans, declares Sajid Nadiadwala, clad in True Religion jeans and Diesel sneakers. Indeed. As he completes a quick meeting with music director Annu Malik lends a cigarette to the writer of his new film, *Kambakht Ishq*, to be shot in Los Angeles with walk-on parts by a few Hollywood notables, and disses this year's Oscar winner *No Country for Old Men*, he knows he is an endangered species in Bollywood. Independent producers, who finance their movies from their own funds and micro-manage their productions (from sitting



MANDAR DEDDAR

VIPUL SHAH DIRECTOR, NAMASTEY LONDON

led to an exchange of letters between him and Hirani's long-time producer Vidhu Vinod Chopra.

For many, becoming an actor is a smart career move. Take Akhtar. Instead of sitting around twiddling his thumbs for his sequel to *Don* to materialise with Shah Rukh—now slated for April next year—he has turned actor for his production company. The first of the movies, *Rock On*, directed by Abhishek Kapoor, about a band is almost complete while he is getting ready to start shooting for sister Zoya Akhtar's long-pending project, *Luck By Chance*, and then begins directing *Voice from the Sky* in September. *Luck By Chance* perhaps typifies the importance of stars more than anything else. Its script has been ready for four years now, but has hung fire because of casting problems—at one time it was supposed to star Vivek Oberoi and Tabu.

Not surprisingly, several deals are being re-negotiated. When Soundarya Rajnikant and Pooja Shetty first agreed to co-produce the multi-lingual animated feature *Sultan The Warrior*, starring Rajnikant, the budget was agreed at Rs 8 crore. By the time they signed on the dotted line, Soundarya as head of Ochre Productions and Shetty as director of Adlabs, the budget moved up to Rs 22 crore. Within a year, by which time Shetty had exited from Adlabs, Soundarya has not only managed to escalate the budget of the digital film to Rs 60 crore but has also wrested total creative control. She's all of 23 and calculates that her earnings from the film will vary between Rs 225 and Rs 275 crore.

Take the buffoonery over *Welcome*, which almost matched its onscreen goings-on. Having made *Welcome* for Rs 25 crore, Firoz Nadiadwala may have thought himself lucky when Indian Films and UTV, fresh from having raised new money in London, chased him for the two-years-in-the-making comedy's worldwide rights. He asked Indian Films for Rs 47 crore, which UTV upped to Rs 50 crore. Having bought it, UTV then re-sold it to Indian Films for Rs 55 crore, happy with a profit of Rs 5 crore. But it's Indian Films that's now sitting pretty, with *Welcome* making Rs 110 crore in revenue.